# 1.1 The Lure of America

Imagine sleeping in a small bed in a cramped room on a ship bound for New York City. The sea is rough. You try to ignore how sick you feel. Instead, you think about the new life you will make in America.

**MAIN IDEA** In the mid-1800s, millions of people from around the world left their homelands and moved to the United States.

## PUSH AND PULL

When groups of people decide to move to a new country, they consider two types of reasons for the move. Some reasons push, or encourage people to **emigrate**, or leave their home countries. Other reasons pull, or encourage people to **immigrate**, or move to another country. Together, these reasons are known as **push-pull factors**.

Throughout history, crop failures, overpopulation, religious persecution, and wars have pushed people from their homelands. Immigrants usually chose to move to countries with plenty of land to farm, a better economy, and freedoms that appealed to them. For example, the Pilgrims' disagreements with the Church of England pushed them to leave England. Available land, the chance to earn a living, and the opportunity to practice their religion freely pulled them to North America. In every century that has followed, the promise of a better life has pulled immigrants to the United States from around the world.

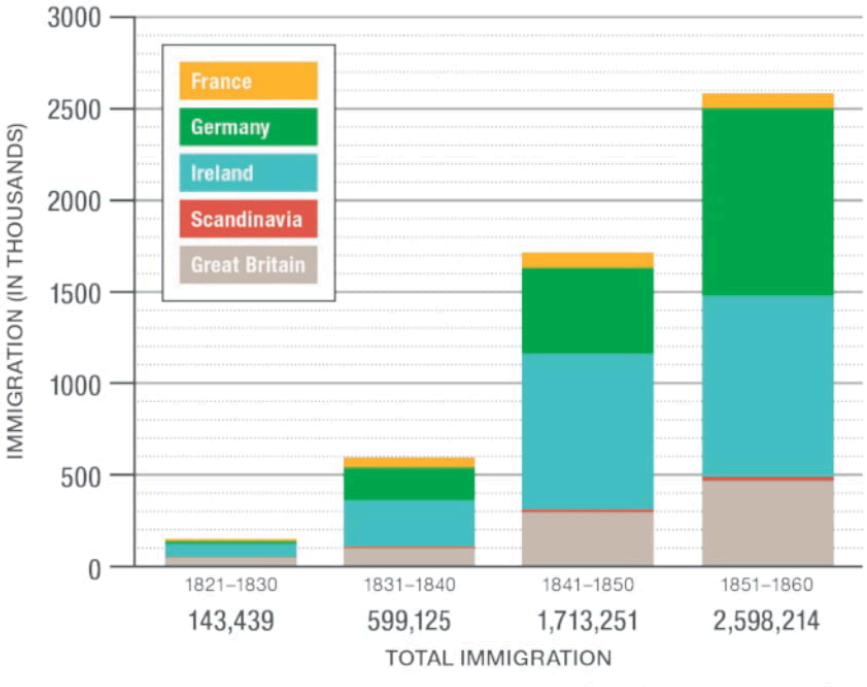
Between 1840 and 1870, more than 7.5 million immigrants came to the United States. That's more people than the total U.S. population in 1810. Wars in Europe acted as a push factor on the people there. At the same time, the United States continued to exert pull factors on people experiencing hardship across the oceans.

## LOOKING FOR OPPORTUNITIES

As you have read, in 1848, word spread in newspapers around the world that miners had discovered gold in California. Many Chinese men emigrated from China, in hopes of finding work in the American West.

Chinese men weren't the only people to immigrate to the United States or its territories to build new lives. Immigrants from northern Europe—including Britain, Ireland, Germany, and Scandinavia—also traveled across the ocean alone or with their families. Their journeys were often difficult. Many immigrants could only afford to travel in **steerage**, a small, confined space between the main decks of the ship. Steerage class was

**European Immigration to the United States, 1821–1860**

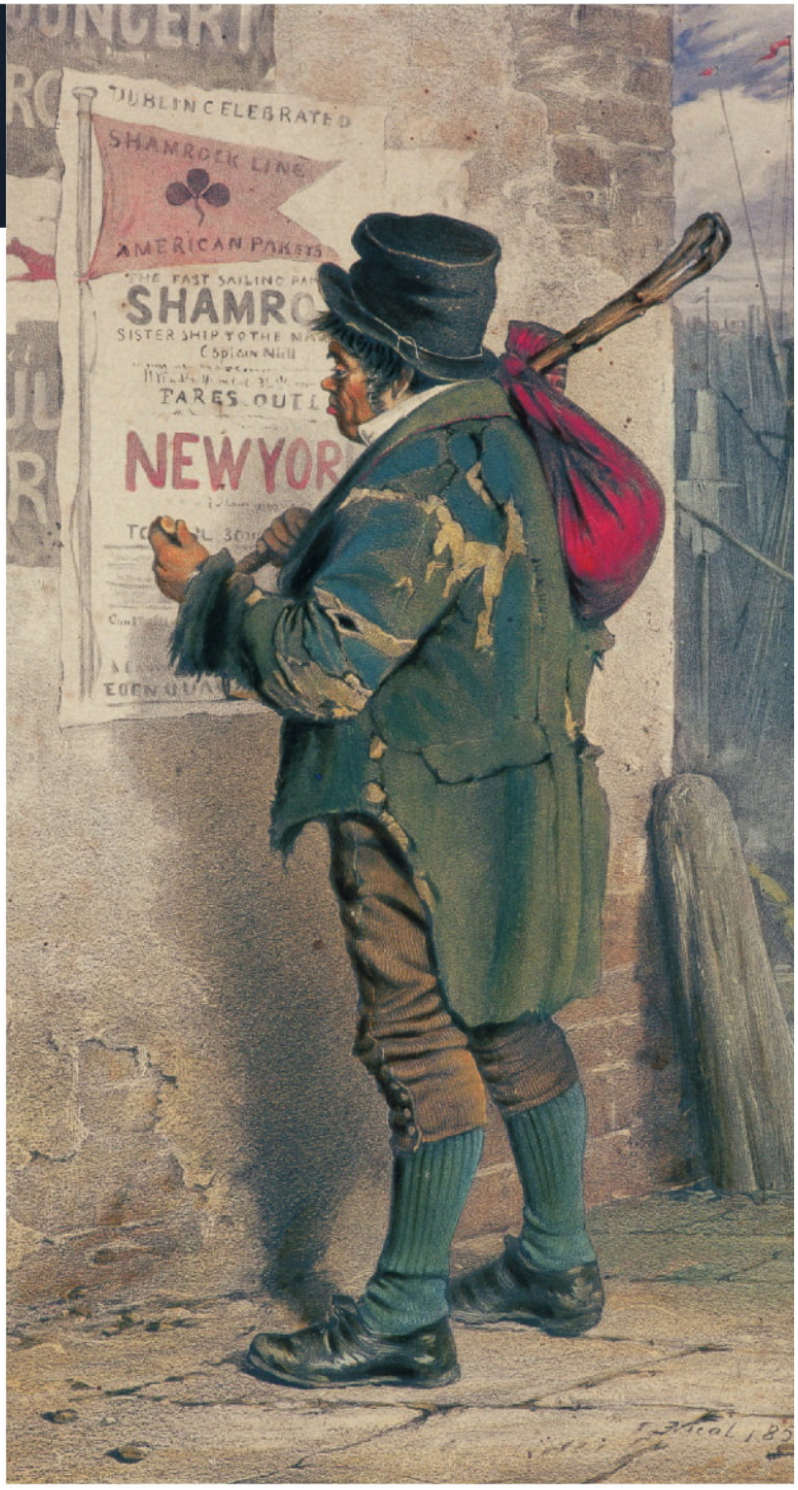



Source: Department of Homeland Security



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**CRITICAL VIEWING** An Irish man in Dublin, Ireland, scours a poster advertising voyages to New York City in this lithograph by T.H. Maguire titled *Outward Bound,* c. 1840–1860. What details do you notice that indicate why he might be interested in leaving Ireland?




an inexpensive way to travel. However, it was crowded and dark, with almost no comforts. Steerage passengers had to bring mattresses, cooking pots, and even their own food for the voyage. Travelers in steerage class also dealt with rats, lice, and fleas during the journey. Seasickness and other illnesses made the area smelly, unpleasant, and unsanitary. Disease could spread rapidly, which was a problem because any illness put immigrants at risk for rejection when they reached the United States.

As new industries expanded in the northeastern United States, immigrants became an important source of labor. They arrived ready to take whatever work they could find in order to survive. The many job opportunities and the established immigrant population of large American cities encouraged many newcomers to stay in the city of their arrival. In fact, New York City had a large immigration center, called Castle Garden, which accepted new immigrants into the country. Immigrants joined with others from their home countries, and they established neighborhoods where people shared similar customs and traditions and spoke the same language. These neighborhoods grew and became vibrant parts of American culture.

The United States welcomed immigrants throughout the 19th and 20th centuries. Some immigrants decided to uproot their families because they hoped for new opportunities. Others wanted to escape a bleak future, or simply to feed their families.

## HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Name two push-pull factors that drove mass immigration in the mid-1800s.
2. **ANALYZE GRAPHS** According to the graph, when did the largest number of Irish immigrants move to the United States?
3. **SYNTHESIZE** How do push factors and pull factors work together?



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